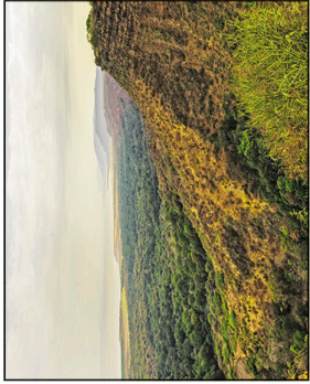


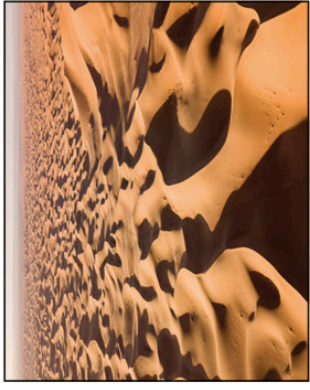
These storm clouds signal the start of the rainy season on the Tanzanian grasslands. Some African birds migrate within Africa, following the rains.

FACTS ABOUT AFRICA



Colossal crack

The Great Rift Valley is about 4,000 miles (6,400 km) long and in some parts it is 22–37 miles (35–60 km) wide. It formed about 25 million years ago when land slipped down between huge cracks, probably due to movements of Earth's crust.



Biggest desert

The Sahara is the biggest desert in the world—it covers an area of about 3.5 million sq miles (9 million sq km). The world's highest sand dunes occur in the Sahara. They can be up to 1,410 ft (430 m) high.

Deep lake

Lake Tanganyika is 4,708 ft (1,435 m) deep and is the second deepest lake in the world. Africa's largest lake is Lake Victoria, but this is only 266 ft (81 m) deep.

Longest river

The Nile is 4,145 miles (6,670 km) long and is the world's longest river.

Spectacular waterfall

The Victoria Falls on the Zambezi River drop 355 ft (108 m) over a ledge 5,580 ft (1,700 m) wide.

Typical birds

Here are just a few examples of typical birds from the most important habitats of Africa. These range from hot, dry deserts and open grasslands to warm, humid rainforests and rivers, lakes, and swamps.

Islands

The cuckoo roller is one of many unique bird families that live only on the island of Madagascar. Others include the ground rollers, asities, and vanga shrikes.

Savanna

There are only two species of oxpecker in the world and they both live on the African savanna. Oxpeckers live on insects, which they take from the skin of grazing animals, such as this giraffe.

Deserts

Most birds find it hard to survive in a dry desert habitat, but the sandgrouse can live well on a diet of dry seeds and fly long distances to water holes.

Rainforests

This pitta is a common bird of the rainforests. African rainforests used to be more widespread, but have shrunk as the climate became drier and as people cut down the trees.

Lakes and rivers

Kingfishers, such as this pied kingfisher, are a common sight around African lakes and rivers, which are rich in food and nesting places.

Marshes and swamps

Large numbers of fish-eating birds, such as this goliath heron, live and feed in vast tropical swamplands such as the Okavango Delta in southern Africa.

Mountains
Birds of prey, such as this Verreaux's eagle, thrive in the African mountains where they can soar aloft rising air currents and see their prey running on the bare ground below.

Hyrax

ATLANTIC OCEAN

KALAHARI DESERT

NAMIB DESERT

Zambezi

Lake Malawi

Lake Tanganyika

Lake Victoria

Congo

ETHIOPIAN HIGHLANDS

MADAGASCAR

INDIAN OCEAN

